

**Nutmeg tree**

An evergreen tree growing to 39 ft (12 m), with aromatic leaves and clusters of small yellow flowers.

Myristica fragrans (Myristicaceae)

Nutmeg & Mace, Rou Dou Kou (Chinese)

Nutmeg and mace both come from the nutmeg tree and have very similar medicinal properties. They are infrequently used in the West because of their toxicity at high dosages, but nonetheless are important medicines, employed principally to stimulate digestion and to treat infections of the digestive tract. Nutmeg also has long been valued as an aphrodisiac and as a remedy for eczema and rheumatism.



Nutmeg and mace are cultivated commercially in the tropics.

Habitat & Cultivation

Native to the Molucca Islands of Indonesia, nutmeg trees are now widely cultivated. They are propagated from seed, sown when ripe. The tree yields fruit after about 8 years, and can continue to fruit for over 60 years. The fruit is picked when ripe and the nutmeg and mace are separated and dried.

Key Constituents**Nutmeg:**

- Volatile oil (up to 15%), including alpha-pinene, beta-pinene, alpha-terpinene, beta-terpinene, myristicin, elincin, safrole
- Fixed oil ("nutmeg butter"), myristine, butyrin

Mace:

- Volatile oil (similar to nutmeg but with a higher concentration of myristicin)

Key Actions**Nutmeg:**

- Carminative
- Relieves muscle spasms

- Prevents vomiting
- Stimulant

Mace:

- Stimulant
- Carminative

Traditional & Current Uses

■ **Digestive problems** Nutmeg essential oil has an anesthetic and stimulating effect on the stomach and intestines, increasing appetite and reducing nausea, vomiting, and diarrhea. It is a helpful remedy for many digestive problems, especially gastroenteritis.

■ **Sleep aid** Though nutmeg is a stimulant, it has narcotic and anticonvulsant properties and can be successfully used at low dose (a pinch of powder will do) as a sleep aid for short- or long-term sleep problems. Laboratory studies also indicate that nutmeg has antidepressant activity.

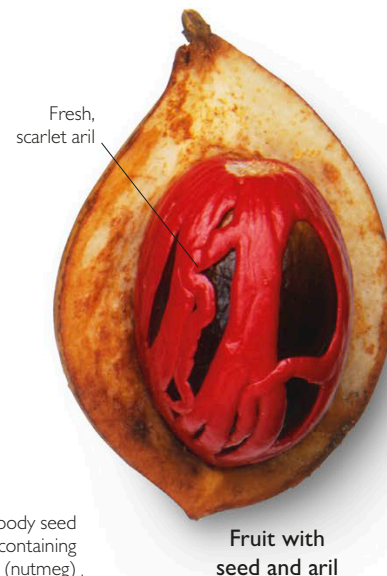
■ **Aphrodisiac** In India, nutmeg has a long reputation as an aphrodisiac. It is believed to increase sexual stamina.

■ **External uses** Ointments based on the fixed oil (nutmeg butter) are used to treat rheumatic conditions. They have a counterirritant effect, stimulating blood flow to the area. In India, nutmeg is ground into a paste and applied directly to areas of eczema and ringworm.

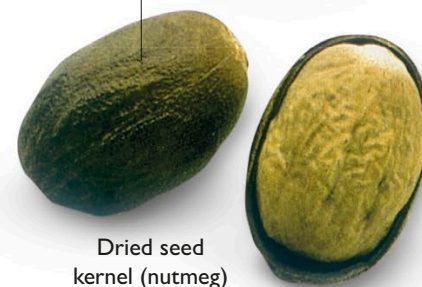
■ **Safety** Low medicinal doses and culinary amounts of nutmeg and mace are safe. In excess, however, the herbs are strongly stimulant, hallucinogenic, and toxic. The consumption of just two whole nutmegs has been known to cause death.

Parts Used

Aril (mace) surrounds the seed casing. It is used in cooking and as a medicine.



Seed kernel (nutmeg) is a stimulant remedy for intestinal infections and rheumatic conditions. In China, nutmeg is known as *rou dou kou*.

**Key Preparations & Their Uses**

⚠ **Caution** Take the essential oil internally only under professional supervision. Do not take more than 3 g of either herb a day. Do not use during pregnancy.



Essential oil of nutmeg is occasionally used by herbalists to treat vomiting.



Powdered mace is prescribed to treat gas and bloating.



Grated nutmeg For eczema, mix 2 tsp with a little water into a paste and apply.



Infusion For gastroenteritis, add a pinch of nutmeg to $\frac{3}{4}$ cup (150 ml) of peppermint infusion (see p. 291). Take 3 times a day.

👉 **Ointment** made from fixed oil (nutmeg butter). For rheumatic conditions, apply several times a day.